

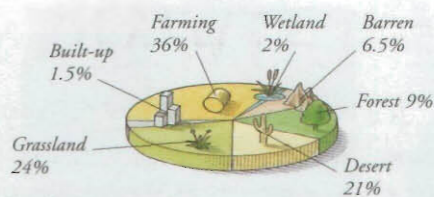
China

 Ruled by the Communist Party since 1949, China is divided into 22 provinces, five autonomous regions, and three special municipalities. Although technically governed from Beijing, many of these are becoming increasingly independent. About 93 per cent of China's people are Han Chinese, and around 60 per cent follow no religion, because the communist rulers discourage religious beliefs. Although fertile land is in short supply, farming is often intensive and employs two-thirds of the work-force. The Olympic Games will be held in Beijing in 2008.

Schoolchildren in Beijing

People

Around 80 per cent of Chinese live in less than half the country's land area, mostly in small villages. However, more than 30 of China's cities have more than one million inhabitants. China's population is growing by 15 million a year, so the government has asked families to have just one child, and fines those who have more. Known as "Little Emperors", single boy children are often spoiled.



Land use

The majority of China's farmland is in the east and south of the country. Much of the desert and mountain regions is uninhabitable. China has large mining areas in the Shaanxi and Sichuan basins, and is the world's largest coal producer.

CHINA FACTS

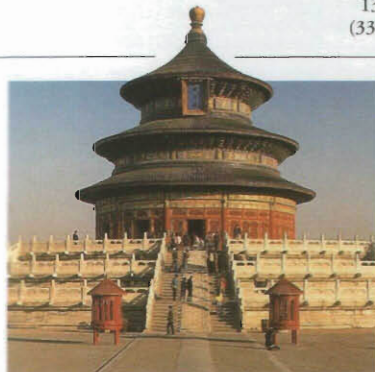
CAPITAL CITY	Beijing
AREA	9,596,961 sq km (3,705,406 sq miles)
POPULATION	1,300,000,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Mandarin Chinese
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Traditional beliefs, Buddhist
CURRENCY	Renminbi (known as yuan)
LIFE EXPECTANCY	70 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	500
GOVERNMENT	One-party state
ADULT LITERACY	84%

Food

Chinese food varies greatly from region to region. Rice is the basis of all dishes in the south, where it grows, whilst in the north, wheat noodles are the staple food. Both noodles and rice are usually served with stir-fried vegetables and meat. Cantonese food is reputed to be the most exotic in China, using rare meats such as snake and turtle. Fish and duck are also served frequently. The Chinese eat with chopsticks held in one hand.



Dry-braised noodles



Temple of Heaven, Beijing

Beijing

For more than 2,000 years, Beijing has been a capital city, either of all China or part of it. Built symmetrically within three rectangles, it is a bustling city of historical buildings, temples, and beautiful parks. The Forbidden City lies at its heart, home to the 15th-century emperor's Imperial Palace. Also from that period is the Temple of Heaven, designed in the Chinese pagoda style.



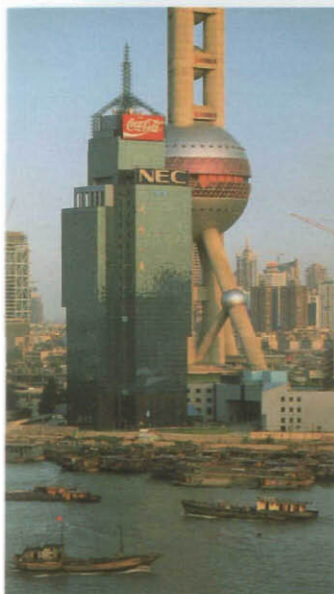
New Year

China's most important festival is the celebration of New Year, which begins in January or February, at the second new Moon of winter. People celebrate with colourful processions and dragon dances and close all shops and offices. Each year is named after an animal.



Leisure

City-dwellers, who have no gardens, are encouraged to take exercise in the well-kept parks. At weekends and on summer evenings, neighbours meet to play board games such as mah jong.



Shanghai

A leading centre of trade and industry and a busy harbour, Shanghai is China's largest city and home to about 16,000,000 people. The city has traditional pagodas and glittering skyscrapers alongside the Chang Jiang River.

Xi'an bicycle factory, Shaanxi



Handle-bars

Industry

China has well-developed heavy industries such as iron and steel. Since the late 1970s, growth has been concentrated in Special Economic Zones in eastern China, where joint Chinese and foreign trade and enterprise are encouraged.

Rice farming

Many women work in flooded paddy fields in southern China. Rice is the main crop, and in a good year two yields can be harvested as well as one of vegetables. When the crop is ready for harvesting, it turns golden. The women cut and tie the stalks into bundles for threshing, which separates the grain and its protective husk from the stalk.



Tibet

The mountainous region of Tibet became a part of China in 1965.

Most Tibetans are devout Buddhists, but under Chinese rule their religious and civil liberties were taken away. Opponents of the government were exiled, and some Han Chinese were resettled in the area, causing tension. The monks still practise their faith and carry out ceremonies, such as offering beer to Buddha in a *hosar*, or New Year, ritual.



Tibetan monk pours Chang beer at hosar festival.